It subsequently occurred to me that given the Department was ultimately responsible to the prime minister, these proposals could not have been cleared so fast without a word from the PM's principal secretary to the foreign secretary. For some time to come, I continued to wonder what was so special about these posts that the PMO had intervened. Contrary to the urgency with which these posts were sanctioned, for a couple of reasons we took some time to start filling them. Firstly, the Department was still reeling from the deep cuts that Morarji Desai had inflicted on its strength. Officers who were parked safely by Suntook in sister organizations such as the Special Service Bureau (SSB) had to be recalled. Also, some new officers had to be inducted. It was also felt that at least for the posts in the US and Canada it would be better if we sent Sikh officers as far as possible, who could read the minds of the local Sikh population. Further, certain time-consuming formalities with respect to their postings on special assignments had to be completed.

Finally, by the end of 1981 we were ready to fill these posts. Officers had to be introduced to the director (establishment), MEA, before their induction into the MEA. Things went smoothly till August 1982 and a couple of posts were filled without a hitch. Then, a Sikh Indian Foreign Service officer took over as director (establishment) at the MEA. The first R&AW officer who was to be introduced to him happened to be from Maharashtra, who had little knowledge of Punjab affairs, not to speak of the Sikh diaspora and their perceived susceptibility to pro-Khalistan propaganda.

So, I personally briefed the officer before his meeting with the director (establishment). Despite my briefing him, the officer concerned didn't feel confident about his knowledge when it came to being asked anything specific on the issue of Khalistan. That was exactly what happened. At the very outset the director (establishment) asked whether the officer really believed there was a Khalistan issue that needed to be addressed in Punjab and how his posting to that particular station was going to help the Department. It was a loaded question and, as expected, my colleague did not know how to address it.